



| NIGERIAN PEOPLES AND CULTURE



MILITARY IN NIGERIA POLITICS

ABIMBOLA OYARINU

Ph.D History and Strategic Studies



LEARNING OBJECTIVE

At the end of the lesson, you should be able to:

- Examine the reason for the intervention of the Nigerian military in politics.
- Describe the role and impact of the military in the Nigerian politics.
- Explore the pros and cons of military dictatorship.





INTRODUCTION

After the first military coup in Africa, which occurred in Egypt in 1952, other African countries have witnessed successive military coups one after the other.

Nigeria is not a stranger to military coups, as it has seen six coups and two attempted coups.

The Nigerian military inherited the British tradition of professionalism and neutrality at all times. The post-Independence era witnessed the politicisation of the military.

Nigeria experienced its first coup on January 15, 1966.



FIRST COUP (1966)

A group of five majors led by Major Chukwuma Nzeogwu Kaduna overthrew the civilian administration of Abubakar Tafawa Balewa.

The coup was considered the bloodiest coup as a number of key officials were murdered which include:

- The Prime Minister: Abubakar Tafawa Balewa
- Sardauna of Sokoto
- Finance Minister, Festus Okotie-Eboh
- Premier of the Western Region, Ladoke Akintola
- Commandant, Second Brigade, Brigadier Zakariya Maimalari
- Commandant, First Brigade, Brigadier S. A. Ademulegun
- Commandant of Nigeria Defence Academy, R. A. Shodeinde
- And lots more.



FIRST COUP

During the coup, which was mainly carried out by officers of Igbo extraction, the plotters perceived it as a revolution and attributed it to the bigotry of politicians in the First Republic.

Nwafor Orizu, the acting President of the Senate, voluntarily transferred power to Major-General Johnson Aguiyi-Ironsi, the highest-ranking military officer, who then suspended the constitution and established an interim federal military government.

The coup was often labeled as an Igbo coup, and it sparked retaliation from officers of northern extraction seeking vengeance for the loss of their leaders, leading to the countercoup.



SECOND COUP: COUNTERCOUP (GOWON) 1966

- A group of soldiers from the north staged a counter coup six months after the first military intervention, which resulted in the overthrow and murder of General Aguiyi-Ironsi's administration.
- The reasons for the counter coup were, first, the fear of Igbo domination in the north; Ironsi's compromising management of the first coup plotters; Ironsi's policies, e.g., the Unification Decree; and the need to exert revenge for the first coup.
- Yakubu Gowon was selected to lead the new government, which he did up until 1975, when he was kicked out of power through a bloodless coup.



THE THIRD COUP (MURTALA MUHAMMED) 1975

At the end of the civil war in 1970, Gowon promised to terminate the military on October 1, 1976. But in 1974, he suddenly announced a postponement of the transition to civilian rule.

A faction of military officers were unhappy with the announcement. These officers led by Colonel Joseph Nanven Garba, overthrew the administration of Gowon on July 29, 1975, in a bloodless coup.

The coup plotters appointed Brigadier-General Murtala Muhammed as Head of State and Brigadier-General Olusegun Obasanjo as his deputy.



FOURTH COUP (DIMKA) 1976

- Lieutenant-Colonel Buka Suka Dimka assassinated Murtala Muhammad. According to Dimka, he attempted the coup because of perceived corruption and maladministration and was arrested without trial.
- However, the coup was unsuccessful as it did not have the support of senior military officers. Government troops crushed the coup attempt, and Lieutenant-General Obasanjo assumed office as head of state.
- Obasanjo returned power to the civilian government of Shehu Shagari.



FIFTH COUP – BUHARI, 1983

After Shagari won his reelection for a second term, a group of coup plotters, led by Major-General Muhammadu Buhari, who was the General Officer Commanding the 3rd Armoured Division in Jos, took action.

The Shagari government was widely criticised for being "inept and corrupt," which became the primary reason cited for the coup.

However, the Buhari-led government was later overthrown by General Ibrahim Gbadamosi Babangida, who was then serving as the Chief of Army Staff.



QUESTION

- At this point, what do you think were the main factors that led to the involvement of the Nigerian military in politics and the occurrence of coups in Nigeria?
- Do you think their involvement was beneficial in Nigeria?



SIXTH COUP (BABAGINDA) 1985

- According to Babaginda, the coup became imperative because of the "rigid and uncompromising" nature of the Buhari regime.
- It was a bloodless coup as Buhari was not in Lagos and his vice president, Idiagbon, was out of the country. Buhari was detained in Benin City until 1988, and Idiagbon was also placed on house arrest for 3 years.
- Babaginda promised a return to civil rule when he seized power. However, on three different occasions, Babaginda found reasons to shift the handover date and consequently ruled Nigeria until 1993.



SEVENTH COUP (ORKAR) 1990

- On April 20, 1990, there was a failed coup attempt to topple the regime of General Ibrahim Babangida. The coup plotters attacked Dodan Barracks, where Babangida was present, but he managed to escape through a back route.
- During the coup attempt, Major Gideon Orkar seized control of the Federal Radio Corporation of Nigeria (FRCN) and announced the secession of the southern part of Nigeria from the north. However, this declaration was swiftly quashed by a high-ranking military officer, and the coup was put down within 10 hours.
- In the aftermath of the failed coup, a total of 42 men, including military personnel and civilians, were arrested, convicted, and subsequently summarily executed in July 1990. The attempted coup and its swift suppression sent shockwaves through the nation.



EIGHT COUP (ABACHA) 1993

- Following the annulment of June 12, Babaginda could not cope with both internal and external pressure; hence, he handed over power to an interim government with Ernest Shonekan as interim president.
- On Nov. 17, 1993, just three months into Shonekan reign, General Sani Abacha launched a coup and overthrew Shonekan government.
- Abacha cited the stagnant nature of Shonekan government and his inability to manage the democratic process as reasons for the takeover of the government.



THE END OF MILITARY RULE

- In 1998, General Sani Abacha died in mysterious circumstances.
- Many believed he had stepped on too many toes following his arrest of Olusegun Obasanjo and Diya Abiola's continued detention.
- After Abacha's death, power was transferred to Abubakar Abdulsalam, who supervised the shortest transition to democracy.
- Olusegun Obasanjo came from prison to contest the presidential election against Olu Falae in 1999, which Obasanjo won to become the elected president of the Fourth Republic.



IMPLICATION OF MILITARY RULE IN NIGERIA

There are pros and cons to the military legacy in Nigeria.

The Pros:

- They kept Nigeria as one.
- Infrastructural Development
- The relocation of the FCT to Abuja
- Creation of States
- Bold policy decisions like NYSC and ECOWAS
- Intentional foreign policy thrust under Murtala Muhammed

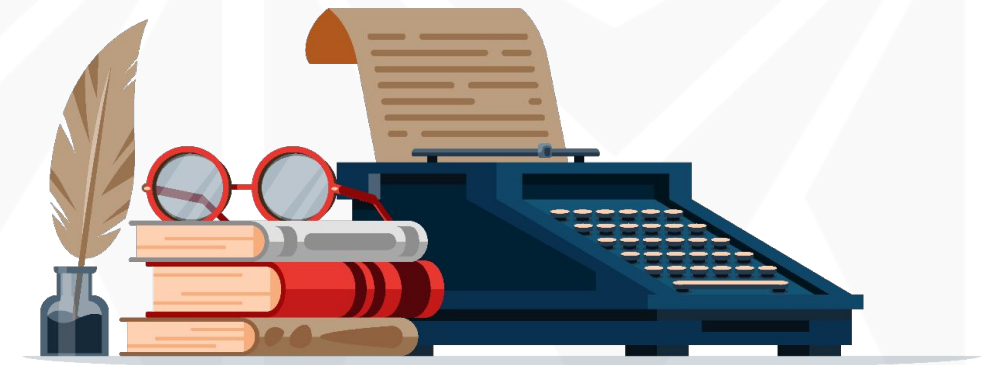




IMPLICATION OF MILITARY RULE IN NIGERIA

Cons:

- The military was responsible for the civil war.
- Corruption and impoverishment
- Lack of checks and balances
- Uncoordinated policy thrust
- lacked the requisite administrative acumen
- Wanton killings and violations of human rights
- Suppression of the Press
- Coups leading to economic uncertainty
- Mismanagement of the Oil Boom
- Stooges of IGOs like the IMF
- Lack respect for the rule of law and the judiciary.





SUMMARY

- It is evident from the above that military intervention in politics derailed the course of progress in Nigeria. Like slavery and colonialism, military rule destroyed existing structures of progress, and in its place, it left a legacy of criminality, abuse of the rule of law, and underdevelopment.
- The long years of military rule are partly responsible for the underdevelopment of the Nigerian state. This is why Awolowo alluded to the fact that the best military government cannot be better than the worst civilian government.
- There should never be a recourse to go back to military rule in Nigeria or Africa at large.





REFERENCES/FURTHER READING

- University of Lagos, Nigerian Peoples and Culture (Lagos, University of Lagos Press, 2013).
- O. Ikime and Historical Society of Nigeria, Groundwork of Nigerian history. Ibadan, Published for the Historical Society of Nigeria by Heinemann Educational Books, 1980.
- S. A Adedire and J. S. Olarewaju, Military Intervention in Nigerian Politics, in Nigerian Politics, edited by Rotimi Ajayi and J. Y. Fashagba, Switzerland, Springer, 2021.



THANK
YOU